

Glossary

Acid

A compound that contains hydrogen, and releases ions of hydrogen when it is dissolved in water. These ions make acids very reactive.

Actinide

A member of a group of radioactive metals with relatively large atoms.

Alchemist

People who experimented with chemicals before the science of chemistry began. Alchemists thought they could turn ordinary metals into gold.

Alkali

A compound that takes hydrogen ions from water molecules when it is dissolved in water. Alkalis react with acids.

Alkali metal

A group of metals that make alkalis when they react with water.

Alkaline earth metal

A group of metals that are found in nature, mainly in alkaline minerals.

Alloy

A material made by mixing a metal with tiny amounts of other metals or non-metals. Steel is a common alloy used in buildings and railways.

Artificial

Something that does not exist in nature. Several elements, including all that are heavier than uranium, are artificially produced by scientists in laboratories.

Atmosphere

The mixture of gases that surrounds a planet or moon. Earth's atmosphere is a mixture of nitrogen, oxygen, and argon, with tiny amounts of several other gases.

Atom

The smallest unit of an element. Atoms are composed of protons, neutrons, and electrons. The atoms of a particular element all have the same number of protons.

Atomic number

The number of protons in an atom of an element. Every element has a unique, unchanging atomic number.

Battery

A device containing chemicals that react to produce an electric current. There are two main kinds of battery: rechargeable and non-rechargeable.

Boiling point

The temperature at which a liquid gets hot enough to change into a gas.

Bond

The attraction between atoms that holds them together in an element or a compound.

Brittle

A way of describing a hard solid that shatters easily.

Carbonate

A compound that contains carbon and oxygen atoms, as well as atoms of other elements. Many minerals are carbonates.

Catalyst

A substance that speeds up a chemical reaction.

Chemist

A scientist who studies the elements, their compounds, and chemical reactions.

Chemistry

The scientific study of the properties and reactions of the elements.

Chemical

Another word for a substance, generally meaning a compound made from several elements.

Combustion

A chemical reaction, involving oxygen, in which a fuel burns to produce heat and light in the form of flames.



Flames are the result of **combustion**.

Compound

A substance made of the atoms of one or more elements that are bonded together in a particular combination.

Conductor

A substance that lets heat or electricity flow easily through it.

Contract

To make or become smaller. Solids, liquids, and gases usually contract when the temperature goes down.

Corrosion

A chemical reaction that attacks a metal, or other solid object, usually due to the presence of oxygen and water.



These vanadinite **crystals** contain the element vanadium.